Perspective

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Integration of Ayurveda and allopathic medicine: Opinion of experts who participated in the working group meetings for the preparation of the WHO benchmarks for the training and practice of Ayurveda

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Abstract

The World Health Organization (WHO) has recognized the importance of integrating traditional systems of medicine, including Ayurveda, with conventional medicine, and has taken several initiatives to promote this integration. The Ministry of AYUSH, Government of India, agreed to host two WHO Working Group Meeting that took place at National Institute of Ayurveda (2018) and at Institute of Teaching and Research in Ayurveda (2019) for developing the WHO Benchmarks in Ayurveda with the participation of 27 experts from the six regions of World Health Organization. These WHO Benchmarks on Training and Practice of Ayurveda were published in March 2022. Excluding the author, 23 (89%) of the experts which participated in the said meetings answered a questionnaire about the integration of Ayurveda and allopathic medicine. A very significant majority of these experts (95%) considered that Ayurveda can make important contributions to conventional medicine and are in favor of the integration of Ayurveda and allopathic medicine. There is also a majority consensus that conventional physicians should have training in Ayurveda at both the undergraduate and graduate levels and that they should have training in Ayurvedic remedies. A large proportion of the experts consulted consider the prevailing view in the Ayurvedic government and official environment in India to be in favor of integration with allopathy, and a significant but somewhat smaller number appreciate this same trend in the Ayurvedic academic field of India. It is significant that almost two thirds believe that in the West Ayurveda should be a specialty within conventional medicine.

Keywords:

Ayurveda, WHO benchmarks, integrative medicine

Introduction

The World Health Organization (WHO) has recognized the importance of integrating traditional systems of medicine, including Ayurveda, with conventional medicine and has taken several initiatives to promote this integration. The WHO Traditional Medicine Strategy 2014–2023 emphasizes integrating traditional and complementary medicine, including Ayurveda, into national healthcare systems. The strategy includes recommendations for promoting research, regulation, and training in traditional and complementary medicine.[1] The initiatives from WHO aim to promote the integration of Ayurveda and other traditional systems of medicine with conventional medicine to improve access to safe and effective health care for all.

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Table 1: Observations from the study questionnaire

Item	Agree	Disagree	Not know/ not answer
Ayurveda can make important and significant contributions to conventional medicine	22	1	0
Ayurveda and Allopathy should take action to promote integration among them	22	1	0
Ayurveda should be taught a subject at the undergraduate level	22	1	0
Allopathic Doctors should have knowledge of basic Ayurvedic principles	21	2	0
Physician´s knowledge of Ayurveda leads to better patient outcome	20	2	1
Should be conducted Postgraduate Courses on Ayurvedic Medicine	20	2	1
The prevailing view in the Ayurvedic governmental and official environment in India is in favor of integration with allopathy	19	2	2
The allopathic doctors should be trained in Ayurvedic remedies	17	6	0
In the western countries, Ayurveda should be a specialty of conventional medicine	15	6	2
The prevailing view of allopathic practitioners outside India is in favor of integration with the Ayurveda	15	4	4
The prevailing view in the Ayurvedic academic environment in India supports the integration with allopathy	14	7	2
The prevailing view of the Ayurvedic practitioners in India is in favor of integration with allopathy	13	8	2
The prevailing view of allopathic practitioners in India is in favor of integration with the Ayurveda	9	10	4

The Ministry of AYUSH, Government of India, agreed to host the WHO Working Group Meeting

for developing the WHO documents, Benchmark for Practice in Ayurveda, Benchmark for Practice in Unani, and Benchmark for Practice in Panchakarma at the National Institute of Ayurveda, Jaipur, from September 17 to 19, 2018.[2] The Ministry of AYUSH and WHO organized the International Experts Consultation Meeting for developing the WHO documents Benchmarks for Practice in Ayurveda, Benchmarks for Practice in Unani, and Benchmarks for Practice in Panchakarma and Updating the Benchmarks for Training in Ayurveda, and Benchmarks for Training in Unani which was held at IPGTR&A at Jamnagar, India, November 26–29 2019. After meticulous review processes, in March 2022, they were presented at the Geneva headquarters with the participation of Dr. Tedros Ghebreyesus, General Director of WHO, and Vd. Rajesh Kotecha, Secretary of Ayush, the "WHO Benchmarks for the training of Ayurveda" and "WHO Benchmarks for the practice of Ayurveda." The "WHO Benchmarks for the Training of Ayurveda" is an update of its previous version published in 2010.[3]

It could be helpful and relevant to consult the opinion of experts from the six WHO regions about different aspects related to the integration of Ayurveda and conventional medicine.

Materials and Methods

The Ayurveda experts who participated in these meetings have answered a questionnaire related to a Ph.D. research project about "Trends, contributions and challenges in the integration between Ayurveda and allopathic medicine." The questionnaire was answered on the spot by 21 experts, while two others sent their responses by mail.

Results

Twenty-seven experts participated in the two meetings; eight participated in both meetings, six only in the first and another 13 only in the second. Three people did not answer the questionnaire, and the author of this paper was also excluded from the investigation. The responses of 23 experts who have the following characteristics were considered:

- Place of residence: 10 resided in India, 2 in the USA, and another 2 in Malaysia, while only one expert per country attended from Spain, Germany, Italy, Latvia, Mauritius, Switzerland, Tanzania, Russia, and the UAE.
- Sex: 17 males and six females
- Average age: 52 years
- Original training: Ayurveda 16, Allopathy 5, Ayurveda and Allopathy 1, Heilpractitioner 1

Training time in Ayurveda: More than 20 years 18; between 11 and 20 years 2; between 1 and 5 years 1; without training in Ayurveda 2 (members of regulatory offices in their countries of origin) [Table 1].

Discussion

Today's globalization allows different visions of health to come into contact. Integrating Ayurveda and allopathic medicine is a complex and highly topical reality that arises both in India and the West. It is of great importance to know, through the verification of authorized opinions, the trends to draw conclusions that may be useful in different countries.

A significant majority of experts favor integrating Ayurveda and allopathic medicine, considering that both medical systems must take measures to promote this process. The almost unanimous opinion emphasizes that Ayurveda can make outstanding and vital contributions to conventional medicine and that its knowledge by

doctors would help improve patient care outcomes. There is also a majority consensus that conventional physicians should have training in Ayurveda at both the undergraduate and graduate levels and that they should have training in Ayurvedic medicines. A large proportion of the experts consulted to consider the prevailing view in the Ayurvedic government and official environment in India to favor integration with allopathy, and a significant but somewhat smaller number appreciate this same trend in the Ayurvedic academic field of India. There would be a current favorable to the integration on the part of the Ayurvedic doctors of India, but opposing opinions are appreciated on the part of the allopathic doctors of India. Significantly, almost two-thirds believe that in the West, Ayurveda should be a specialty within conventional medicine.

The integration of Ayurveda and allopathy has several potential advantages, including:

- Holistic approach: Ayurveda focuses on the holistic approach to health, which includes physical, mental, emotional, and spiritual well-being. Integrating Ayurvedic principles into allopathy can help to provide more comprehensive and personalized health care.
- Prevention: Ayurveda emphasizes the importance of preventing disease before it occurs through lifestyle modifications and the use of natural remedies. Integrating Ayurvedic principles into allopathy can shift the focus from treating disease to preventing it.
- Safety: Ayurvedic interventions are generally considered safe and have fewer side effects compared to some allopathic medicines. Integrating Ayurveda with allopathy can help to reduce the risk of adverse reactions to conventional medicines.
- Cost-effectiveness: Ayurvedic interventions are often more cost-effective than allopathic medicines. Integrating Ayurveda into conventional health care can reduce healthcare costs and improve access to healthcare for all.
- Complementary approach: Integrating Ayurveda with allopathy can provide a complementary approach to health care. By combining the strengths of both systems, patients can benefit from a more holistic and personalized approach to health care.

It is highly likely that the publication of the benchmarks by the WHO, along with the actions taken by the Ministry of Ayush in India, as well as academic and research initiatives undertaken by renowned Ayurvedic institutions, and the growing interest in Ayurveda observed in the majority of countries, will stimulate a fruitful dialogue between these two medical systems that undoubtedly will benefit patients and the general population.

The sample was representative of the experts invited by the WHO and Ministry of Ayush to prepare the Benchmarks on Ayurveda. Although the response rate was good for a survey instrument, the sample was small, and it cannot be ensured that the experts' answers represent the majority opinion on the subject. Since the study is cross-sectional rather than longitudinal, we do not have information on the actual attitude change over time. Due to the study's limitations, it is necessary to carry out more representative studies of the opinions on the subject in the different WHO regions.

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Nil.

Conflicts of interest

There are no conflicts of interest.

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1. WHO Benchmarks for the training of Ayurveda. Editors: World Health Organization; 2022.
2. WHO Benchmarks for the practice of Ayurveda. Editors: World Health Organization; 2022.
3. Benchmarks for training in traditional/ complementary and alternative medicine: benchmarks for training in Ayurveda. Editors: World Health Organization; 2010.